

states PUNJAB

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

There is no shorter fuse in Punjab than the volatile mix of politics and religion. Last week, the state was perilously close to a sectarian flare-up after Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, the head of the Sirsa-based religious sect, Dera Sacha Sauda, inflamed Sikh passions by imitating Guru Gobind Singh. Sikh leaders were outraged, triggering a violent face-off between the sect and the Sikhs.

As the frenzied protests against the controversial godman swept the Sikhs across the country, the three-month-old Shiromani Akali Dal-BJP Government, led by Parkash Singh Badal, was pushed deeper into a crisis. Brandishing *kirpans*, Sikh hardliners took to the streets across the state. Delhi rushed a 5,000-strong paramilitary force to maintain law and order as the situation was clearly beyond the control of the Badal Government. At the Akal Takht, the temporal seat of the Sikhs inside the precincts of Amritsar's Golden Temple, radicals thronged the sun-baked marbled *parikrama* asking for the blood of the Dera's chief.

The Government booked the Sacha Sauda chief under Section 295-A of the



The face-off between Sikh radicals and the Dera Sacha Sauda threatens to take the state back to the violence



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IPC with non-bailable warrants, for hurting the religious sentiments of the Sikhs and forced him to offer regret in order to defuse the crisis. But the Sikh clergy rejected his regret letter and directed the sect to wind up its Deras across Punjab by May 27. This in turn raised the hackles of the ruling alliance partner, BJP, and the Congress, which termed it as a "fascist *fatwa*". The Congress had, incidentally, taken the help of the Sacha Sauda during the Assembly elections three months ago. Following the clergy's ultimatum, 53 deras that are on the hitlist of the Sikh radicals have been given round-the-clock security.